My Left Breast

By Susan Miller

NOTE: This cutting met the requirements for PROSE by the National Speech and Debate Association in 2008. Rules governing the PROSE category have changed over time and this selection no longer meets the requirements for PROSE by the NSDA as it is a monologue from a play.

State rules governing PROSE vary from state to state, so please verify your state's current rules before competing with this selection in the PROSE category.

[I COME OUT DANCING. Then, after a moment.]

The night before I went to the hospital, that's what I did. I danced. *[Indicates breasts.]* One of these is not real. Can you tell which? *[Beat.]*

I was fourteen the first time a boy touched my breast. My left breast, in fact. I felt so guilty with pleasure I could hardly face my parents that night. *[Beat.]* Anyhow, breast cancer.

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INTRODUCTION

Every 13 minutes a woman dies of breast cancer. It is little wonder then that the fear of breast cancer takes a considerable emotional toll on many women. Because breast cancer is so common, almost person has known at least one woman who has been diagnosed with breast cancer, and many have lost friends or relatives to the disease. Consequently, breast cancer is, perhaps, the most feared illness among women.

And how do you face your fear . . . . George Carlin once stated "Those who dance are considered insane by those who can't hear the music." But perhaps it's not insanity . . . perhaps it is just one way to cope with the fear. At least it seems so for Susan Miller in her autobiography . . . My Left Breast.

The year it happened my son was eight. He looked at my chest, the day I told him. We had these matching Pep Boys tee shirts. You know - Manny, Mo, and Jack. He looked at my chest and said, "Which one was it? Manny or Jack?"

"Jack," I tell him.

"What did they do with it?"

"I don't know."

He starts to cry. "Well, I'm going to get it back for you1"

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Now he is twenty and I am still his mother. I am still here. We are still arguing. He is twenty and I wear his oversized boxer shorts with a belt and he borrows my jackets and we wear white tee shirts and torn jeans and he says, "Why don't you get a tattoo."

"A tattoo?"

"Over your scar. It'd be cool." *[Beat.]* Here's what I wear, sometimes, under my clothes. [*Show BREAST PROSTHESIS to audience.]* Don't worry. It's a spare. *[Beat.]*

When you go for a fitting, you can hear the women in the other booths. Some of them have lost their hair and shop for wigs. Some are very young and their mothers are thinking: Why didn't this happen to me, instead? And there's the feeling you had when you got your first bra, and the saleswoman cupped you to fit. Cupped you and yanked at the straps. Fastened you into the rest of your life.

[Beat.]

I miss it but it's not a hand. I miss it but it's not my mind. I miss it but it's not the roof over my head. I

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miss it but it's not a word I need. It's not a sentence I can't live without. I miss it, but it's not a conversation with my son. It's not my courage or my lack of faith. *[Beat.]* I miss it.

A man I know said to me, Lesbians are the Chosen people these days. No AIDS. I said, Lesbians are women. Women get AIDS. Women get ovarian cancer. Women get breast cancer. Women die. In great numbers. In the silent epidemic. He said, I see what you mean. *[Beat.]* I miss it but I wouldn't have to if anyone paid attention to women's health care.

The surgeon in Los Angeles said it was a fibroadenoma. "Someday you might want to have it removed," he said. "But no rush. It's benign." I watched it grow. Then in New York, I saw another surgeon. He said, "What have you been told?"

"Fibroadenoma, " I say.

"Well, I'm concerned," he said. "I want to biopsy it."

You know how when everything is going right, you figure it's only a matter of time until that bus swerves

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on to the sidewalk or you finally make it to the post office to buy stamps and that's the day a crazed postal worker fires his Uzi into the crowd.

Everything was going right for me. I had just won an Obie for a play at the Public Theatre. I had a contract for my first novel- I was in the beginning chapters. And a new relationship.

The gynecologist said it was a gland. When it didn't go away, she sent me to the surgeon who said it was something it wasn't.

All of this happened at the beginning of a new decade. When we would all lose our innocence. It was 1980. In New York. I heard the Fourth of July fireworks from my hospital bed. I was thirty-six. I was too young. People were celebrating. And they were too young for the plague that was coming.

There were two positive nodes. I went through eleven months of chemotherapy and I had only one more month to go. But at my next to the last treatment, after they removed the IV, the oncologist and his nurse looked at me with what I distinctly recognized as

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menace. I thought, they're trying to kill me. If I come back again, they'll kill me. I never went back.

There are those who insist that certain types of people get cancer. So I wonder, are there certain types of people who get raped and tortured? Are there certain types who die young? Are there certain types of Bosnians, Somalians, Jews? Are there certain types of gay men? Are there certain types of children who are abused and caught in the crossfire? Is there a type of African American who is denied, excluded, lynched? Were the victims of the Killing Fields people who couldn't express themselves? And one out of eight women - count 'em folks - just holding on to their anger? This is my body - where the past and the future collide. This is my body. All at once, timely. All at once, chic. My deviations. My battlescars. My idiosyncratic response to the physical realm. The past deprivations and the future howl.

I am a One Breasted, Menopausal, Jewish Mom and I am the topic of our times. I am the hot issue. I am the cover of Newsweek, the editorial in the paper. I am

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a best seller. And I am coming soon to a theatre near you. Excuse me, I need to scream now. *[SCREAMS.]*

That was good. But what I really want to do is break a chair. *[Beat]*

I have destroyed so much property in my mind. I have smashed so many plates against the wall, ripped so many books from cover to cover. In my mind, I have trashed apartments, taken all the guilty parties to court. Done damage for damage done. But I'm the accommodating patient. I move on. Get over it. Exercise restraint. I am appropriate. *[Beat]*

I miss it but there is something growing in its place. And it is not a tougher skin. *[Beat.]* The doctor says my heart is more exposed now. Closer to the air. You don't have any protective tissue, she says. I hardly need a stethoscope to hear it beat. I cherish this scar. It's a mark of experience. It's the history of me. A permanent fix on the impermanence of it all. A line that suggests I take it seriously. Which I do. A line that suggests my beginning and my end. I have no other like it. I have no visible reminder of the baby I lost. Or the

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friend. No constant monument to the passing of my relationship. There is no other sign on my body that repeats the incongruity and dislocation, the alarm. A scar is a challenge to see ourselves as survivors, after all. Here is the evidence. The body repairs. And the human heart, even after it has broken into a million pieces, will make itself large again.

My son did get it back for me. In a way. Not the year it happened. But the year after that and the year and the year and the year after that. *[Beat.]*

It was little league that saved me. It was Jeremy up to the plate. It was Gabe Goldstein at second. It was Chris Chandler catching a pop fly. It was Jeremy stealing home. It was providing refreshments and washing his uniform. It was trying to get him to wear a jock strap. It was screaming, "Batter. Batter. Batter." It was Jeremy pitching the last out with the bases loaded. It was the Moms. The Moms and Dads and the coolers. It was the hats we wore and the blankets. It was driving him home from practice. It was his bloody knees. It was the sun going down on us, watching our

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sons and daughters play and be well. *[Beat.]* This was the cure for cancer.

I miss it, but I want to tell all the women out there, that we are still beautiful, we are still powerful, we are still sexy, we are still here.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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